WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

JAMAICA

Americas

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Kingston and St Andrew	Capital and commercial centre; seat of government, the Bank of Jamaica and the Jamaica Stock Exchange, and home to the Kingston Freeport Terminal transshipment port operated under a PPP concession	Financial services, logistics, business process outsourcing, real estate
Montego Bay / St James	Tourism capital and main gateway for visitors through Sangster International Airport, itself a PPP concession, with a large cluster of outsourcing operations	Tourism, aviation services, business process outsourcing
Negril / Westmoreland and St Elizabeth (south-west)	Area most affected by Hurricane Melissa and now the focus of reconstruction, with hotels steadily reopening and the island's main farming parishes being restored	Reconstruction, resilient housing, hotel refurbishment, agriculture
Ocho Rios and the north coast (St Ann, Trelawny)	Established resort and cruise corridor on the north coast, benefiting from 1.3 million winter-season airline seats scheduled for 2026/27	Tourism, cruise services, hospitality real estate
Bauxite-alumina belt (central parishes)	Historic mining and alumina-refining base; output is recovering from a temporary post-hurricane fall	Bauxite, alumina, mining services, energy
Special Economic Zones (regulated by JSEZA)	Zones under the 2016 SEZ Act offering a 12.5% corporate income tax rate, zero GCT on zone purchases and customs relief	Light manufacturing, logistics, outsourcing, export services
Caribbean shipping lanes / Panama Canal approach	Strategic location close to the Panama Canal and North American markets supports Jamaica's role as a regional transshipment and logistics hub	Port logistics, warehousing, ship and cargo services

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- JAMPRO (Jamaica Promotions Corporation), the national trade and investment promotion agency, provides sector targeting, investment facilitation and aftercare
- Open investment regime: no foreign-ownership limits, no screening mechanism and no sector-specific market-access restrictions, backed by bilateral investment treaties with the US and UK, ICSID membership and the New York Convention

- Special Economic Zones Act 2016, administered by the Jamaica Special Economic Zone Authority (JSEZA), offering a 12.5% corporate income tax rate (which may fall to 7.5%), zero GCT on zone purchases and customs duty relief
- Omnibus incentive legislation, including an Employment Tax Credit of up to 30%, duty-free capital equipment and raw materials, relief for large-scale and pioneer projects, and a 33.3% investment tax credit in Urban Renewal Special Development Areas
- Junior Market of the Jamaica Stock Exchange, offering a five-year income tax holiday followed by a 50% rate for a further five years for qualifying listings
- Freely floating Jamaican dollar with no restrictions on converting, transferring or repatriating investment funds, in line with IMF Article VIII
- Public-private partnership and privatisation programme led by the Development Bank of Jamaica, with a track record including Kingston Freeport Terminal, both international airports and the Wigton Wind Farm

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Jamaica in October 2026 combines more than a decade of disciplined economic management with a recovery that is running ahead of schedule. Public debt fell from more than 130% of GDP in 2013 to 60.3% in September 2025, and stood at an estimated 65.6% at end-March 2026 despite hurricane-related spending — below the 68.9% the government had projected. Credit ratings have held with stable outlooks since the hurricane (S&P BB, Fitch BB-, Moody's Ba3), and a $1 billion 11-year international bond priced at 6.25% in September 2026 drew orders of around $2.5 billion. Foreign direct investment rose 15% to $351 million in 2025, gross international reserves reached $6.6 billion at end-August 2026 (143.9% of the IMF adequacy measure), and murders fell 42% in 2025 to the lowest level since 1994. The Planning Institute of Jamaica (PIOJ) projects a return to growth of 1–3% in FY2026/27, with output back at pre-hurricane levels by April–June 2027, well ahead of the three years initially expected.

Jamaica's main structural challenge is its exposure to extreme weather, and its response to Hurricane Melissa has demonstrated the value of preparation. The Category 5 storm struck in October 2025, causing damage estimated by the World Bank and IDB at $8.8 billion, around 41% of GDP; output fell 7.1% year-on-year in October–December 2025 and the contraction narrowed to 2.9% by April–June 2026, with seasonally adjusted growth of 3.3% in the first quarter of 2026. A pre-arranged, multi-layered disaster risk financing framework paid out quickly, including CCRIF parametric payments of $91.9 million and a $150 million catastrophe bond, complemented by a $415 million IMF Rapid Financing Instrument; Jamaica then placed a new $200 million catastrophe bond in May 2026. Public capital spending rose 55.8% in April–June 2026, and hotel room capacity is projected to reach 88% by December 2026 and full recovery by May 2027, supported by 1.3 million winter-season airline seats, 23% above 2025. Reconstruction is creating sizeable opportunities in resilient housing, power and water networks, hotel refurbishment and insurance.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Hurricane and climate exposure	Hurricane Melissa caused damage estimated at around 41% of GDP in October 2025, and the island remains exposed to Atlantic storm seasons	Jamaica's pre-arranged disaster risk financing, renewed with a $200 million catastrophe bond in May 2026, cushions shocks; investors can build resilient design and parametric cover into projects, and reconstruction itself is a major opportunity
Pace of tourism reconstruction	Around 3,000 hotel rooms are expected to remain closed at the start of the 2026/27 winter season, with insurance payouts cited as a constraint	Capacity is projected at 88% by December 2026 and full recovery by May 2027; refurbishment, resilient construction and hospitality investment are in demand
Higher inflation and monetary tightening	Inflation rose to 8.6% in September 2026 as supply effects from the hurricane fed through, and the Bank of Jamaica raised its policy rate to 6.0%	The Bank expects inflation to return to target by mid-2027, supported by $6.6 billion in reserves and a stable currency; apply standard hedging for local-currency exposure
Temporary suspension of fiscal rules	Fiscal rules were suspended after the hurricane and debt rose to an estimated	A long record of consolidation, stable ratings and strong market access for the

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	65.6% of GDP at end-March 2026, against a 60% target	September 2026 bond underpin credibility; the next Fiscal Policy Paper will set the path back to target
Crime and public safety	Crime remains a business-cost consideration, although murders fell 42% in 2025 to the lowest level since 1994	Use established security providers and locate in well-served business districts and zones; the sharp improvement strengthens the case for tourism and services investment
Court delays and administrative process	Commercial cases can take years to resolve and corruption remains a public concern, with Jamaica ranked 73rd of 180 in the 2024 Corruption Perceptions Index	Use international arbitration under the New York Convention and ICSID, rely on the US and UK bilateral investment treaties, and engage JAMPRO for facilitation
Concentration in tourism and alumina	Accommodation output fell 12.2% and aluminium production 30.8% in April–June 2026 as hurricane effects worked through	Diversification into outsourcing, logistics and SEZ-based manufacturing is widening the base and offers entry points beyond the traditional sectors

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Jamaica's risk profile reflects an economy with a strong record of macroeconomic discipline, deep market access and a well-prepared approach to natural-disaster risk. The country's debt reduction since 2013, stable credit ratings and an oversubscribed $1 billion bond in September 2026 show that investor confidence has held firm through the largest storm in its recent history. Hurricane Melissa's impact was substantial, but pre-arranged insurance, catastrophe bonds and IMF support were deployed quickly, and the PIOJ now expects output to regain pre-hurricane levels by mid-2027. Inflation has risen temporarily and the Bank of Jamaica has responded promptly, with reserves well above adequacy levels. Crime and slow court processes remain practical considerations, offset by a marked fall in murders and access to international arbitration and investment treaties. Investors should build climate resilience and insurance into project design, while those in construction, utilities, tourism and services are well placed to benefit from the reconstruction cycle.

MARKET ACCESS

Jamaica is a member of the Caribbean Community (CARICOM) and its Single Market and Economy, and a WTO member, giving preferential access to regional Caribbean markets. Exports enter the United States on preferential terms under the Caribbean Basin Economic Recovery Act, the European Union through the CARIFORUM–EU Economic Partnership Agreement, the United Kingdom through the successor CARIFORUM–UK agreement, and Canada under CARIBCAN. The island's English-speaking workforce, time-zone alignment with North America and location close to the Panama Canal underpin its role in transshipment through Kingston and in nearshore services. This combination of North American proximity, Caribbean integration and European trade preferences gives Jamaica a well-diversified market access profile for export-oriented and services investors.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Andrew Holness)	Leads the national recovery and growth agenda; Holness secured a historic third consecutive term in September 2025	Primary reference point for strategic direction and large-scale investment priorities
JAMPRO (Jamaica Promotions Corporation)	National trade and investment promotion agency; principal facilitation body for foreign investors	Standard first point of contact for market entry, incentives and site selection
Bank of Jamaica	Inflation-targeting central bank that manages the floating Jamaican dollar and $6.6 billion of gross reserves	Relevant for currency, banking and financial-sector matters
Ministry of Finance and the Public Service	Manages fiscal policy, debt and the disaster risk financing framework, and led	Key counterpart for public finance, reconstruction funding and tax matters

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	the September 2026 $1 billion bond	
Jamaica Special Economic Zone Authority (JSEZA)	Licenses and regulates SEZ developers and occupants under the 2016 SEZ Act	Essential partner for manufacturing, logistics and outsourcing projects seeking zone incentives
Development Bank of Jamaica (PPP and privatisation programme)	Runs the PPP and privatisation pipeline behind the airport, port and wind-farm concessions	Primary channel for infrastructure and reconstruction-related PPP opportunities
Ministry of Tourism	Leads recovery of Jamaica's largest foreign-exchange earner, including airlift growth and a planned tourism resilience fund	Relevant for hotel investment, refurbishment and tourism-linked services

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Private Sector Organisation of Jamaica (PSOJ), the Jamaica Chamber of Commerce and the American Chamber of Commerce of Jamaica are the leading business associations, alongside sector bodies such as the Jamaica Manufacturers and Exporters Association, the Jamaica Hotel and Tourist Association and the Global Services Association of Jamaica for the outsourcing industry. JAMPRO runs investment promotion events and trade missions and maintains sector-specific outreach. The World Bank and IFC, the Inter-American Development Bank, the Caribbean Development Bank and the IMF are closely engaged in post-hurricane recovery, and their programmes are a useful source of project pipelines and co-financing in housing, energy, water and private-sector development. The large Jamaican diaspora in the US, UK and Canada also provides strong commercial and investment networks.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Jamaica suits investors seeking exposure to a well-managed, English-speaking economy entering a reconstruction-led recovery: construction, engineering and building-materials firms supporting the rebuilding of housing and infrastructure; utilities and renewable-energy investors focused on resilient power and water networks; hospitality groups and real-estate investors positioned for the tourism rebound; business process outsourcing and logistics investors drawn by SEZ incentives, nearshore positioning and the Kingston transshipment hub; and insurers and financial-services firms meeting growing demand for risk-transfer solutions. Investors should incorporate climate-resilient design and appropriate insurance cover into project planning.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage JAMPRO and assess incentive options
Open direct dialogue with the national investment promotion agency to identify the most suitable incentive route, whether SEZ, omnibus incentives or Junior Market listing.

STEP 2: Map the reconstruction and PPP pipeline
Engage the Development Bank of Jamaica and multilateral partners to identify housing, energy, water and transport projects open to private participation.

STEP 3: Evaluate SEZ structuring for export-oriented operations
Consult the Jamaica Special Economic Zone Authority on licensing and incentives for manufacturing, logistics and outsourcing projects.

STEP 4: Build climate resilience and insurance into project design
Draw on the lessons of Hurricane Melissa by using resilient construction standards and parametric or conventional cover appropriate to the asset.

STEP 5: Track the tourism and macroeconomic recovery
Follow PIOJ growth estimates, Bank of Jamaica inflation decisions and hotel capacity milestones to time entry into tourism and consumer-facing sectors.